

Artists and AI: Creative Interactions and Tensions

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ABSTRACT

Advancements in artificial intelligence (AI) technologies have enabled new forms of artwork production. Artists engaged with AI have developed individual practices within their field. In this paper, we present a qualitative study to explore the tensions that arise in this new practice. We conducted and analysed 10 interviews with artists who work creatively with AI. We broaden the scope of attention beyond only the mechanisms of user-AI interaction to consider the personal, inter-personal, practical and ethical tensions for participants. We uncover how participants manage aspects such as expectation, reception and criticism.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI**.

KEYWORDS

Artificial Intelligence, AI Art, Creative AI, Cultural Studies, Qualitative Interviews

ACM Reference Format:

Charlotte Bird. 2024. Artists and AI: Creative Interactions and Tensions. In *Extended Abstracts of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI EA '24)*, May 11–16, 2024, Honolulu, HI, USA. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 6 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3613905.3651041>

1 INTRODUCTION

Artists and creative practitioners have long played an active role in exploring, contending and revealing a number of issues related to emerging technologies such as artificial intelligence (AI) and large-scale data use [2, 12, 24, 26]. Such artists appropriate new AI technologies in their creative practice as tool, material or subject. Often they build, re-purpose, subvert or break AI technologies to their own creative purpose, aesthetics and meaning [6, 7]. Analysis of this practice can offer more than simply an investigation of human-AI interaction, but can inform questions and debates arising in human-computer interaction (HCI) research around designing for desirable technological futures [11]. We present an analysis of 10¹ interviews with professional artists working with AI. We shape our analysis in recognition of the broadening scope of attention within HCI from user-focused to relation, actor and experience

¹Further interviews have been scheduled.

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CHI EA '24, May 11–16, 2024, Honolulu, HI, USA
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ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-0331-7/24/05
<https://doi.org/10.1145/3613905.3651041>

focused, offering an analysis that extends beyond the mechanisms of AI interaction [11]. We analyse the reported tensions and complications engendered by creative use of AI for identity, practice, ethics and future imaginings. To our knowledge, this study is the first to qualitatively survey this number of artists working with AI.

2 RELATED WORK

Since the famous sale of "Portrait of Edmond Belamy" in 2018 [15], there has been an increasing fascination in art made with AI [7]. Enabled by the steady release of accessible generative models such as DALL-E 2 [22] and Stable Diffusion [23], users are now able to immediately generate high-quality images. As a result, researchers in a number of different fields have turned to analysing the political, cultural and socio-technical dimensions of AI in artistic practice. Recent work includes an in-depth analysis of the practice and politics of five critical AI artists [6], which highlighted, amongst other conclusions, the significance of ethics as imbued into creative AI practice. Ploin et al. [20] explore the changes in practice enabled by AI, concluding that human creativity remains beyond the remit of current AI capabilities. Hemment et al. [12] offer an analysis of critical AI work as a tool to facilitate public learning and literacy around AI technologies. Further, Leibowicz et al. [16] provide a field guide for responsible creation with AI art, acknowledging AI as a unique tool with new affordances. Alternatively, Allred and Aragon [1] explore why online artist communities have turned away from AI tools. Artists have also been considered in the risks and harms related to AI-based systems, such as reputational damage, economic loss and copyright infringement [2, 14, 19]. In addition, a number of studies have compared and contrasted human art with AI generated art [10, 13, 21, 27] in order to understand emotional perceptions and reactions to AI art. Similarly, research has compared the outputs of Midjourney from both artists and non-artists, concluding that emotional communication should be privileged in AI art creation [17]. Further work has posited that the bias towards human art arises from an anthropocentric defense of human uniqueness narrative [18].

There is, as shown, a growing body of work that investigates the creative practice and politics of AI in art. Our study offers the largest qualitative survey of artists working with AI², to understand the tensions that arise in identity, practice and ethics. We position the larger study as a means to understand and shape the future of AI tools for creativity by mapping the concerns of current AI creative practitioners.

3 METHODS

For this exploratory study, we conducted 10 semi-structured interviews. A list of themes was developed which contained simple

²To our knowledge

prompts: personal history and practice (previous and current roles, personal interests, values, education, previous and current practice), AI in practice (how they use AI, how often, changing use of AI, reception of their work) and finally AI in society (ethical concerns, responsibility, safety, future imaginings). These themes were developed in collaboration with an experienced second researcher, and were designed to allow the artist to construct a complete picture of their experience with AI [9].

3.1 Participants

The recruitment of participants relied on scoping work in which we manually identified and collected artists working with AI. We utilised research groups, exhibitions, workshops, collectives, galleries, museums and personal contacts to collate professional artists working with AI. We selected participants who had published or exhibited work that broadly related to machine learning based systems, such as critical investigation of existing systems or using generative models or similar tools in the creative process (where disclosed). We then contacted artists for their participation via email. We also requested identification of contacts who also met our criteria. All interviews were conducted over video conferencing systems. Informed consent was obtained. During transcription we removed identifying features such as names and locations to protect the anonymity of the participants. All participants are professional creatives and artists who exhibit their work to the public. The authors had the explicit intent to recruit artists with a wide variety of methods, aims and focuses. As such, this dataset encompasses artists who work in music, theatre, digital and moving image, robotics, sculpture and data visualisation, amongst others.

3.2 Analysis

Each interview lasted between 30-45 minutes and was audio-recorded. The data collected in the interviews was transcribed. Firstly, all transcripts were read and analyzed with relevant passages highlighted. We applied an inductive approach to coding [3], whereby themes are drawn from the raw data. Inductive coding was chosen in order to account for the breadth of experiences presented by our participants. The transcripts were read and coded, then themes were identified across transcripts, under which codes were then grouped.

4 FINDINGS

In this study, we observe that artists contend with a number of complications and tensions when they make art with AI. In the following section we explore the participants' creative identity. We then explore the tensions that arise in our participants creative practice and their interactions with AI as tool and material. We address the tensions that artists feel in relation to ethics and responsibility and finally how they imagine the future of AI and creativity.

4.1 Identity

We began our discussions by asking about an artist's personal history. We focused on previous and current roles, education, and how they came to work with AI. We allowed participants to freely report on this. We primarily wanted to understand how a participant's

identity informs their practice with AI. We noted a number of tensions for our participants. These include how they balance differing roles, such as educators, researchers and technologists.

4.1.1 Art and Research. Notably, the first tension that arose for many of our participants was not related to the practice of working with AI, but to the impact this practice had on their artistic identity. Many of our participants are both researchers and artists. They work freelance, or across private technology companies, universities and colleges. There is often a friction between their identities as participants manage the disparate aims and paths of their roles. P4 explained that the financial inequality between roles is very challenging, primarily because we have high expectations for the function of art and the role of the artist:

"I see think-tanks and initiatives talk about the importance of art, but the artists are never paid as much as the postdocs, or the professors or the PhD holders or the data scientists." - P4

Other participants discussed this expectation for the function of art, but instead noted the dichotomy between the pressure to create important, interesting and engaging art versus the push towards critical AI discourse. Participants who work in research highlighted the difficulty of contributing to the creation of AI technologies whilst working to critique them. To resolve these tensions requires placement of ethics and critical engagement at the core of their practice; however this is often complicated by their reliance on the corporations who design their tools. Many of our participants were practising artists long before their use of AI. Yet many feel their identity has been reduced or invalidated by the ethical concerns attached to AI tools. For some, this is inescapable:

"I wouldn't have a practice without these tools. I've never had a creative engagement without technology." - P2

4.1.2 Diversity. AI practice also created a second tension in identity. Unlike artists who work within other mediums such as painting, our artists often think about the potential impact of their personal perspectives. A number of artists mentioned the importance of diversity in artists and communities making art with AI. Some mentioned how diversity leads to better technology, whilst others noted that diversity enables consideration of a broader range of communities. Participants noted the importance of including diverse communities because the impact of AI technologies is global. This is especially important for artists like P1, who investigates and maps critical issues such as climate change using AI. However, whilst diversity and inclusion is critical, our participants mentioned how it enables the off-loading of responsibility from corporations onto individuals by removing the onus from corporations to build safe, diverse and inclusive teams and products. Further, artists often feel a greater degree of responsibility as their work becomes the medium through which audiences come to explore AI in alternative ways.

4.2 Practice

The interviewed artists discussed their creative practice and processes. We discussed where AI exists within their practice, how

often they use it and how the role of AI has changed as the technology has developed. We also extended this discussion beyond the mechanisms of practice to discuss reactions to practice and the community of other AI artists.

4.2.1 Process and Interaction. Our participants have varying levels of interaction with AI, from using image generators to building their own tools. However we found similarities in how our participants interact with AI and the tensions that arise within these interactions. Firstly, participants mentioned feeling disillusioned and looking to move away from their current methods. This is precipitated not only by the increasing power and capacity of ML-based systems enabled by exploitative data practices, but the increasing focus and uncovering of the negative and unsafe downstream effects of using AI systems. For example, P4 stated:

"The more I pursue human rights, the more I am lost on what I used to like about it. I actually realized what makes it harmful, and so I think for me that's the hard thing to square." - P4

Other artists find tactics to avoid enabling negative effects. P3, who uses image generators, only uses their own imagery for seed prompts. P8 uses a human to select LLM generated lines, and prefaces their performance with the potential harms of LLMs. However, whilst we discussed such strategies, participants continued to share feelings of disillusionment. For those who use image generators, the problems could not be entirely mitigated. P2 discussed that these issues go much deeper: whilst an artist can take meaningful steps toward ethical interaction, they are restricted by the choices made by developers (such as the data used in training of the foundation model). P2 further noted that we do not yet have the language to untangle the complications of these ethical concerns.

Further, artists find themselves limited by the capabilities of AI systems and often turn to inventing their own pipelines and workflows. Our participants build their own tools, systems and datasets when skills allow, but often artists are confined by their technical knowledge, which create an exclusionary environment for the probing and understanding of AI systems.

4.2.2 Reception. We found that our participants frequently experience negative reactions to their practice, despite the steps they take to avoid harm. Importantly, negative reactions were reported even when artists use AI as a subject, not a medium or material, or when artists build their own tools. Some of our artists' work only speaks to the issues surrounding AI, yet they still report the same negative reactions. For example, P2 stated:

"they were so antithetically, politically opposed to the idea of, they don't even think you can ethically make critical work." - P2

P3 noted that their students were "horrified" at the idea of using AI in their practice, whilst P1 noticed students feeling AI posed a threat to their role as artists. These reactions are informed by and reflected in popular AI discourse of risk and safety. However, participants mentioned the need to foster positive conversations about AI in order to re-frame our thinking towards responsible technological mediation rather than as a defense of human attributes [25]. For example, we discussed using AI as a tool for disabled artists, or using LLMs to help artists explain their work to audiences.

In addition, a number of our participants noted that inclusion of AI technologies in creative practice often provokes unreasonable expectations from audiences and curators. For example, meaningful and creative interaction with AI technologies takes time, as shown in previous studies [4], and relies on the extensive previous experience of the artist. The expectation of speed was especially felt by participants who frequently use image generators in their practice. P2 often uses a generative model for their commission work for which they have built a personalised pipeline. P3 uses a generative model in their process to create images. Both participants noted that using image generators does not speed up or simplify their creative process, contrary to popular opinion. P2 found that people who commission them do not realise the time and skill needed to create quality results, and:

"they came to a genAI solution as an automated way of this process and found that it actually needs longer." - P2

P3 also noted the extensive work needed to produce their artwork:

"it takes probably 100 images or more to produce 1." - P3

This extends beyond commission work also. P1 echoed the same sentiment in their discussion of galleries and curators, that they feel there is an expectation of rapid responsiveness to make work that engages with the immediate cultural moment, as: "audiences might engage better." This expectation of rapid generation is amplified by a more significant expectation: fostering new, critical perspectives [12].

4.3 Values, Ethics & Responsibility

In continuation of our discussions around community and reception, we focused on personal values, ethics and responsibility. We discussed the existence of responsibility, how participants deal with responsibility, how they feel about the broader discussions of AI safety and responsibility, and how they manage presentation of their work.

4.3.1 Values. Importantly, our participants often reported that ethics and responsibility are central to their practice. This is strongly informed by the personal values and history of the artist. For example, P4, P6, P7, P8 and P10 use their practice to probe and analyse ethics. In addition, numerous participants mentioned they feel a responsibility to create an experience for the audience in which they can question and think critically — this is scaffolded from the personal values and ethics of the artist. Critical creation with AI often demands an interrogation of the artists personal values: a significant task.

4.3.2 AI Safety Discourse. In our discussions of AI safety, responsibility and ethics, participants frequently mentioned the friction between the discourse of existential risk and safety generated by corporations, and the ground truth of their interactions with AI. The dominance of such risk and safety dialogue meant that some artists felt they had to justify and defend their use of generative models and other AI technologies, despite the technology usually occupying a minimal role in their practice. P7 noted the dominance of the existential risk dialogue and the real effects it has had on

their practice, such as limiting the capabilities of tools like ChatGPT. P7 states:

“this framing of these tools as very dangerous plays into the hype that the companies want, it’s really just about market value.” - P7

P6 noted that often artists can further feed into this hype by enhancing the mythical capacity of their tools as a way to gain attention and traction for their work. For our participants, how their work is framed and received poses a difficult ethical dilemma because as P6 noted:

“you don’t have to think about navigating ethically, you can make an unethical artwork.” - P6

This sentiment is strongly echoed by other artists who stated that art can simply exist as art, and artists do not have to be visionary if they work with AI. However this sentiment exists in tension with the discourse of AI safety, as our participants mentioned that the corporate and academic focus on AI risk and safety devalues art into a means to do research and development, provide risk forewarning or surface connections. AI in practice becomes implicitly loaded with expectation of social or ethical commentary whilst subsequently being reduced to a mechanism within AI safety discourse. Our participants discussed the impossibility of balancing between these facets.

4.3.3 Audience. For our artists who produce installation or live work, there are a specific set of complications they must manage, and they do so in similar ways across their different practices. P6, a critical artist who examines AI technologies in relation to topics such as geo-politics, often produces live installation work. P7 and P9 create tools or objects related to data or robotics, whilst P8 and P10 have created live shows. Despite their differing forms of practice, they all mention the ethical complication of pursuing live work with AI. P6 states, in relation to voice assistants as an installation:

“I don’t want them turned on. That doesn’t agree with my ethics to expose audiences to live functioning data capitalism.” - P6

P6 instead probes the materiality of these objects without utilising the machine learning function, whereas P8 utilises language models but takes steps to avoid negative outcomes in their live performance such as using a human to pick generated lines. Our participants are highly cognizant of the potential harms of their materials, and the avoidance of such harm greatly impacts the work they undertake. Manufacturing a controlled but exploratory experience for the audience is central to the practice of a number of our participants. In this way, the experience of the audience as interrogative becomes central to the practice, which is often not the case in other practices.

4.4 Future Imaginings

The extent to which our present and future is shaped by technology has likely never been so visible. Computers, the internet, big data and AI seem to pervade our existence, and will continue to do so. Consequently, many artists use their practice as a means to advocate or contemplate possible futures. This contemplation is not limited to artistic practice, but is reflected in HCI as we consider what we create and subsequently what we will become from

those interactions [11]. We discussed how our participants imagine technological futures, what they wish to see and how they believe this can be shaped.

4.4.1 Complications. Whilst the interviewees made statements about the importance of shaping and advocating for possible futures, we also noted the tensions that arise from these artistic imaginings. Our participants noted that any future imaginings implicitly exist within the confines of our extractivist techno-capitalist society, and as such the impossibility of communicating a true alternative future, as P6 noted:

“We have been denied all sorts of possible futures that we don’t have and never saw, because this one future got done on a very low budget.” - P6

Other participants echoed this same disillusionment, and mentioned the complications of working with AI for future visions when AI technologies like image generators rely on the extraction and commodification of data. Further, artistic engagement is complicated by the ever-changing landscape of human-technology interaction, especially in the case of AI. P6 mentioned *“unfinished thinking”* in regards to working with AI technologies, wherein the form and meaning of our engagement are constantly shifting, and artists must constantly stay up to date on technological development, find new ways to create, foster new perspectives, advocate for and communicate better futures.

4.4.2 Centering the Human. We further discussed the ways in which participants can shape and advocate for new futures. Interestingly, across varying practices participants held very similar ideas — centering human physicality, experience and emotion. This shift is reflected in Verbeek’s [25] argument for a post-phenomenological shift away from designing interactions to designing and understanding complex human relationships [8, 11].

P9 summarised this as:

“it’s not about developing AI as human, but how can we live nicely together. If we can’t stop development then we need to reduce those tensions, we’re focusing on what humans need.” -P9

Further, P10 detailed their approach as:

“But what does it mean to start interacting with AI in the real world, and especially with our own bodies, feeling it?” - P10

Our participants felt strongly about the role of technologies in shaping human existence, beyond simply designing for best interactions. For example, not only asking whether image generators are exploitative but asking what we become in that interaction and who we wish to be [11]. Our discussions of entanglement and futures also surfaced a number of tensions that our participants contend against. Primarily, these ideas and potential futures exist in tension with dominant AI development and discourse that does not recognise the importance of moving towards meaningful relations rather than optimising user experience and increasing shareholder value. As such, changing this perception or incorporating this shift into their work becomes a tremendous responsibility for artists working with AI.

5 DISCUSSION

This study explored the practice of 10 artists working with AI. From the interviews we have drawn a number of insights. We now highlight our key findings and offer comparisons with other artist studies. Finally, we note limitations of this study.

5.1 Key Findings

Creative engagement with AI is often a highly introspective, ethically complex and challenging process. Likely due to prevalence and reception of image generators such as Stable Diffusion, AI art is often cast aside as shallow pastiche. However we have shown — as have others [5, 20] — that human-AI creativity is complex and an ethically, personally challenging pursuit.

Creative engagement with AI is often an underpaid, under-utilised and underappreciated method of exploration. Studies that explore artistic engagement with AI often begin from a view of AI art legitimacy and and thus do not probe how artists may feel undervalued or underappreciated. We also recognise that AI discourse is often dominated by academic and industrial research. Our ongoing study aims to understand how we can better value and utilise AI artists, their knowledge and practice.

Narratives of AI safety and existential risk have a significant impact on artistic practice. The work of Caramiaux and Fdili Alaoui [6] highlights the epistemological values of AI research culture, and finds that artists do not adhere to them. Their artists re-frame AI systems to become a critical material, just as our participants do.

Tensions arise outside of practice that meaningfully affect artist engagement with and approach to AI. We wanted to extend our analysis beyond “where and how are AI tools successful or unsuccessful?”. In doing so, we found number of tensions around reception of art, including artists building guardrails around AI technologies whilst still choosing to use them.

5.2 Limitations

This study has a number of limitations typical of interview-based qualitative studies, such as our reliance on the willingness of participants to share experiences and opinions. However we also wish to highlight that the developed themes shaped the direction of discussion, can potentially be too steering. Whilst we strove to develop themes that allowed for a broadening discussion of AI practice, semi-structured interviews encourage the discussion of the pre-determined themes. For example, during the final theme (AI in society), participants were encouraged to discuss any aspect of AI in society they wished. However it is possible that questioning methods led towards discussions of ethics, given their significance in AI discourse and our desire to touch upon the subject.

Finally data saturation has not been reached yet with the current sample size of 10, though many further interviews have since been conducted. Despite these limitations, we observed a number of valuable insights related to AI in creative practice, and we hope that this exploratory work and the work that follows will provide a foundation for further research into AI as a creative tool and material.

6 CONCLUSION AND FUTURE WORK

This paper provides an exploration of the tensions that arise for artists who work creatively with AI. Our findings show that creative AI practice is often highly complex and personally challenging. Unlike previous studies, we have extended our analysis beyond only the mechanisms of practice to situate creative AI work within the relations and associations between audience, the public, the artist and technologies. However, more research is required. We have already conducted and scheduled a number of further interviews. In addition, we plan to expand our analysis beyond tensions endemic to the practice. Finally, our findings emphasise the difficulty of practicing with AI, and we wish to pursue research that can address how to better design and think about this new medium and tool.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

This work was supported by the Arts and Humanities Research Council grant number AH/X007146/1. Charlotte Bird is supported by the Baillie Gifford PhD Scholarship at the Centre for Technomoral Futures at the University of Edinburgh.

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